sustainable. While we tend to think of connectivity in physical terms, let us not forget that it has its softer aspects that are actually no less important. People-to-people contacts, religious travel and exchanges, heritage conservation and cultural promotion are all enabling factors that can contribute to a greater sense of bonding among societies. It is, therefore, essential that we approach the connectivity challenge with a holistic perspective – community-centred, not transactional – that has a purpose of common good as its primary driving force.

No analysis of the Indian Ocean would be complete without capturing the development at its extremities, be they the eastern coast of Africa or the Pacific Islands. The holding of Pacific Islands Summits and the enhancement of our engagements and development projects is important to the realization of our shared goal of climate justice. The story of India in Africa has similarly not got the attention it deserves, partly because it does not play to the gallery. Ties with East African countries on the Indian Ocean periphery with whom we have longer historical contact and closer proximity are particularly relevant to the Indo-Pacific debate.

The Indian Ocean is about people, culture and commerce. Appreciating its complex texture and intricate nuances is essential to nurture its growth and resurgence. It should be approached with empathy, not as a business. It must be treated as a partner, not as an arena. The goal must be interdependence, not dominance. While the monsoons may no longer dictate when ships can travel, yet its rhythms still pervade the lives of billions of people. The Ocean is renewing its status as a zone of encounters and crossroads of culture. The time is approaching for it to come back into its own, which is critical to the prospects of the Indo-Pacific.

To realize that India must take a contributing approach that partners others to build their capacity and secure interests. At another, it must be consultative in this engagement, whether bilateral or regional, or even in respect to the maritime commons. The willingness to shoulder greater responsibility must continue. After all, it is in one sense a maritime variant of our proud tradition of UN peacekeeping. Equally important is the message of respect for international law and norms, where India’s behaviour speaks louder than any words. Responding to extra-regional